

*Eighty Days* (1872). The protagonist, Phileas Fogg's adventures around the world starts with a *Daily Telegraph* report of a new railway line laid in India, making it possible to see the world in 80 days. He makes it to Bombay and takes a train to Kholby, where the line, contrary to the news report, lies about 80 km short of completion. Verne's India, full of palanquins, tigers, holy lands, and indigo fields, has all the makings of an "Orientalist tourist brochure", notes Indian author Arup K Chatterjee in his 2018 book *The Purveyors of Destiny: A Cultural Biography of the Indian Railways*.

Verne's novel, much like most of pre-Independence writing on the railways, mirrors the colonial enterprise, where the native is the noble savage and the English, a civilizing force. So too, in English writer Rudyard Kipling's 1893 story *The Bridge Builders*, which symbolizes the triumph of colonialism and immortalizes his real-life observations of the construction of the Kaiser-i-Hind or Sutlej Bridge (in present-day Pakistan). Kipling's works, Canadian historian Ian J Kerr notes, "contributed to the British experience of railway travel" as well. More so, after AH Wheeler and Company, a chain of bookstores operating in stations across the country (see [The AH Wheeler Story](#)), published his writings in 1888 as a part of the "Indian Railway Library".

In contrast, American author Mark Twain views India from a distinctive, non-colonial lens. In *Following the Equator: A Journey Around the World* (1897), the description of his train journeys are almost romantic. "It was a very large station, yet when we arrived it seemed as if the whole world was present – half of it inside, the other half outside," he wrote.